TANGKHUL-NAGA GRAMMAR: A STUDY OF WORD FORMATION AND MORPH

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ABSTRACT:

This study provides the first comprehensive modern morphological analysis of Standard Tangkhul Naga by a native linguist. Focusing on word-formation strategies, the dissertation examines the typology of roots, derivational prefixes, inflections, and compound formations. We investigate nominal compounding (endocentric and exocentric), reduplication, verbal valency alterations, and postpositional case affixation, demonstrating how Tangkhul balances agglutinating morphology with analytic syntax.

Keywords: Word Formation, Morphology, Affixation, Compounding, Valence, Ahum, Ukhrul

1. MORPHOLOGICAL TYPOLOGY & ROOT CLASSES

Tangkhul word formation operates primarily through agglutination with strict suffixal dominance in nominal inflection and prefixal dominance in verbal derivation. Monosyllabic lexical roots fall into three major syntactic categories: Noun roots (shim 'house', ram 'country'), Verb roots (sa 'do', thei 'see', zat 'go'), and Deictic/Particle bases (hi 'this', chi 'that'). Nominal roots can occur bare as free morphemes, whereas verbal roots generally require affixes or compounding.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** shim (house) -> shimkhar (village community) -> shimsak (construction) : Nominal root extension**

Analysis: Root compounding.

*** tui (word) -> tuitam (lesson) -> tuingashik (covenant) : Discourse compounding**

Analysis: Semantic broadening.

2. NOMINAL COMPOUNDS & GENDER MARKERS

Compounding is the most productive lexical expansion mechanism in Tangkhul. Compounds exhibit head-initial and head-final constructions. Natural gender in animate nouns is marked not by grammatical inflection but by sex-specifying enclitics: -va for feminine (e.g. siva 'bitch', harva 'hen') and -mayar for masculine (simayar 'male dog', harmayar 'rooster').

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** mayarnao (man/son) / ngalanao (woman/daughter) : Human gender terms**

Analysis: Root + gender enclitic + diminutive nao.

*** haiku (cooking vessel) -> meiku (fire basin) : Utensil compounding**

Analysis: Endocentric nominal compound.

3. VALENCE MODIFICATION & ASPECTUAL INFLECTION

Tangkhul verbal roots undergo valence modification through prefixation and auxiliary compounding. Reflexives take prefix nge- (ngathang 'wash oneself'), reciprocals take nge- with root reduplication (ngazek-ngazek 'converse mutually'), and causatives take suffix -sak. Completive aspect is marked by -ser, durative by -kapam, and future intentional by -ra.

Tangkhul Linguistic Data & Analysis:

*** ana i-li theisaku : He caused me to see (showed me)**

Analysis: Causative suffix -sak.

*** athum ngayeiserie : They all love one another completely**

Analysis: Completive aspect -ser.

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